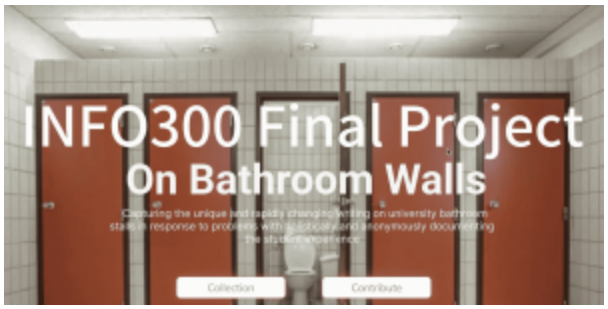
On Bathroom Walls: Designing Digital Space for UBC's Unspoken Stories

POSTED ON MARCH 28, 2026 BY CHELSEA



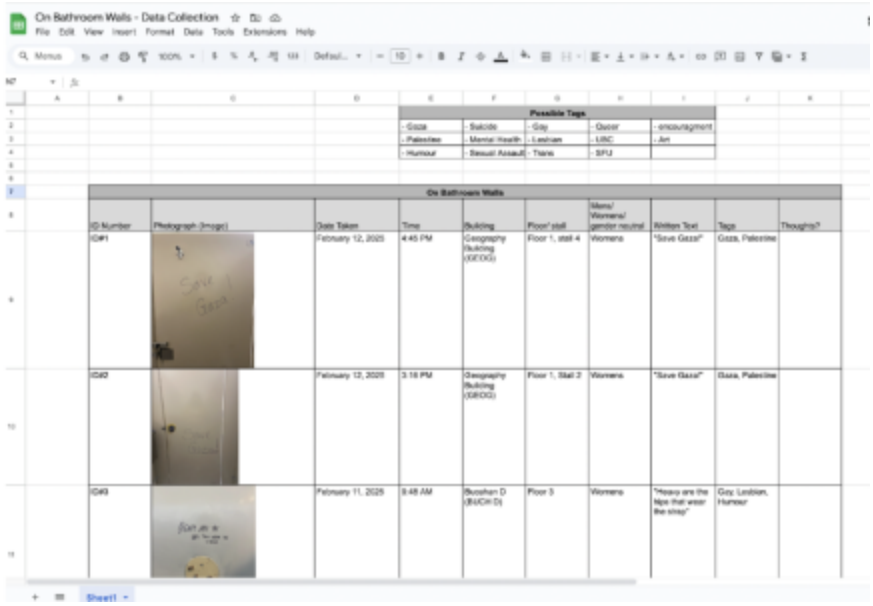
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"On Bathroom Walls" is an archive network that captures the unique and rapidly changing writing on university bathroom stalls, created in response to the challenge of holistically documenting the student experience. These writings offer an introspective lens into students' raw feelings, concerns, and creativity within a private yet collaborative space. I applied user-centered design to build a digital space that preserves these testimonies.

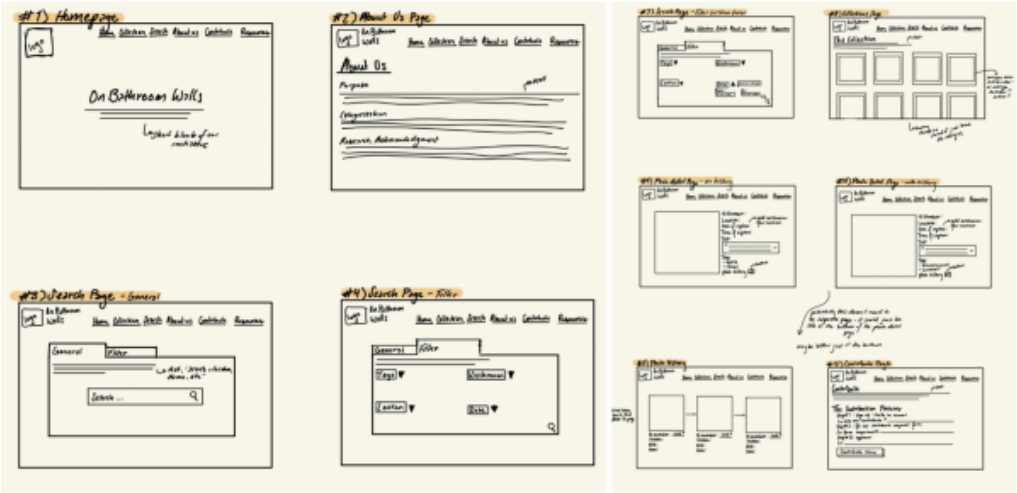
As a visual designer for the On Bathroom Walls project, I learned that ambiguity is not an obstacle—it is part of the creative process. My goal was to build a digital archive preserving the writings, doodles, and markings found inside bathroom stalls across UBC campus—a space where students express honest, uncensored thoughts on everything

from school policies to mental health. The challenge was that these messages are often erased quickly, and we wanted to create a digital home where they could be saved, revisited.

Research Collections:

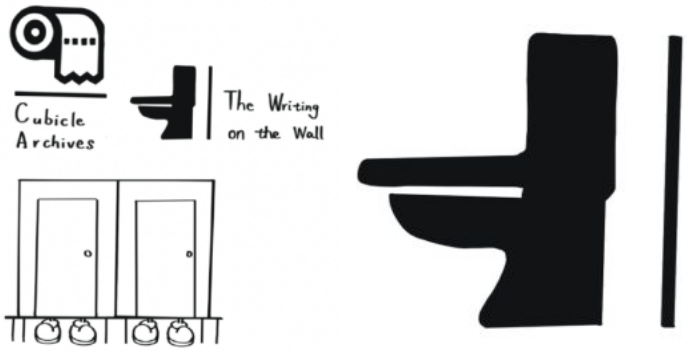


Sketches:



The project was more complex than I initially imagined. I wrestled with fundamental questions: Should the site be formal or casual? Should users simply view content or actively contribute? How do I maintain anonymity while fostering a sense of community? There were no clear answers—only trial and error. But one thing remained constant: The users were at the heart of every decision. This experience taught me the importance of empathy—truly understanding the needs and emotions of those we are designing for.

Logo Design:



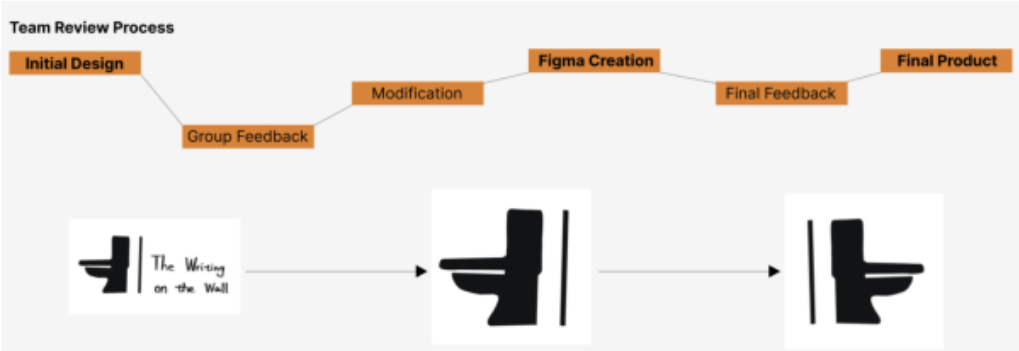
My primary role was leading the visual design. I was responsible for the logo, typography, colour scheme, icon set, and seven pages of the Figma prototype. The logo became my deepest learning experience. I began with hand-drawn sketches in Procreate—rolls of toilet paper, stall doors, toilets, handwritten fonts—each intended to capture the intimate, expressive nature of bathroom graffiti. After team feedback that my initial designs were "too busy," I simplified to a single toilet graphic. With professor feedback, I further refined it into a clean, black-and-white minimalist icon that immediately conveyed the spatial context without needing words. This iterative process—sketch, feedback, revise, repeat—taught me the value of active listening and collaboration. I learned that great design is not about ego or getting it right the first time, but about being open to input and trusting the process.

Colour Palette:



The technical side pushed me outside my comfort zone. Figma was entirely new to me, and building the dropdown menu for our filter system tested my patience. I built it, deleted it, rebuilt it, and failed repeatedly. I felt stuck so many times that I wanted to give up. But with persistence and help from teammates, it finally worked. This taught me resilience and problem-solving—that being stuck is not failure, but a necessary step toward growth. I also learned the importance of teamwork: asking for help is not a weakness, but a strength that leads to better outcomes.

Design Process:



Beyond visuals, we faced an ethical challenge: how do we design a platform that preserves the rawness and anonymity of these messages without stripping away their emotional weight? We did not want the site to feel overly "designed." That is why I kept the visual tone minimal and respectful—no flashy colours, no complex layouts. We

anchored our palette in burnt orange for structure and warmth, with pumpkin orange for interactive elements. This taught me adaptability—the ability to balance creative vision with user needs and project constraints.

Home Page Design Drafts:



A turning point came when we added a submission feature. Initially, the site was static—users could view but not contribute. But a site called On Bathroom Walls felt like it should be built by the community. Once we opened the door for contributions, the project came alive. This decision taught me critical thinking—recognizing that the best solutions often come from questioning our assumptions and staying aligned with the project's core purpose.

Final Prototype:



The Meaning Behind the Project

To me, this project was about more than building a website. It was about understanding how people communicate when they feel invisible. Bathroom stalls are one of the few spaces on campus where students leave behind honest, uncensored thoughts—without the pressure of identity, visibility, or validation. These writings are not meant to start conversations or seek feedback; they are quiet, momentary expressions that exist precisely because they are ephemeral and anonymous.

We were not just creating a platform for anonymous sharing—we were preserving something that exists because it is fleeting, intimate, and site-specific. The real challenge was not just displaying these writings, but maintaining the integrity of their context and mood. This project deepened my understanding of emotional intelligence—the ability to sense what people need even when they do not say it directly—and cultural awareness, recognizing how different spaces shape the way we express ourselves.

Through this experience, I grew not just in technical skills but in empathy, resilience, collaboration, and critical thinking. I learned that ambiguity is not something to fear—it is where creativity lives. We did not have all the answers at the beginning; we found them

by building, testing, talking, and reworking. And in doing so, I discovered that the best design does not just look good—it connects, respects, and gives voice to those who need it most.

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LEARNING SIGNIFICANCE



PROFILE

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Education

University of British Columbia

Faculty of Arts (2022 — present)

Media Studies Major

Work Experience

Unique Get Together Society (2024)

Marketing Team Member

Hebei Antu Trading Co., Ltd. *(2026)*

Social Media Operations Intern

Pinky Floy*(2023)*

Retail Associate

Community Service

UBC Mood Psychology Club（2024 – Present）
Volunteer, Communications Member

SKILLS

Design (4)

Communications (3)

User-Centered Mindset (3)

Creativity (3)

Collaboration (3)

Attention to Detail (2)

Adaptability (2)

Time Management (2)

Building Connections (2)

Problem Solving (2)

Oral Presentation (2)

Storytelling (1)

Social Media Management (1)

Data Visualization (1)

Project Management (1)

COURSES

INFO250 (1)

INFO300 (1)

INFO419 (1)

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